

Research Statement

Kingsford Onyina
Ph.D. Candidate, Public Policy Analysis

My research lies at the intersection of social policy, international development policy, and applied econometrics. I study how the design, timing, and implementation of public policies shape well-being over the life course, particularly among economically vulnerable populations, using modern causal-inference methods. I am especially interested in social safety nets, examining not only their effects on intended beneficiaries, but also how those effects spill over across household members and generations. My empirical work spans the mature welfare state of the United States and the evolving social protection systems of sub-Saharan Africa, with the common goal of generating rigorous evidence to improve policies designed to level the playing field.

Dissertation and Current Research Agenda

My current dissertation is centered on cash assistance programs, which is a critical social policy tool to reduce poverty, stabilize vulnerable households, and improve long-run wellbeing. By transferring resources to disadvantaged families, they aim to support economic security and human capital development and break the cycle of dependency. Some programs are conditional, tying support to work and behavioral requirements, while others are unconditional, providing income without direct labor market obligations. These differences shape how households allocate time, respond to incentives, invest in children, and adjust to financial constraints. Evaluating cash assistance therefore requires examining how policy design influences behavior and life chances over time. This dissertation studies these dynamics across two policy settings: the United States, where welfare reform introduced a conditional, work-oriented regime, and Ghana, where LEAP 1000 operates as an unconditional cash transfer.

In my job market paper, I study the 1996 welfare reform which replaced Aid to Families with Dependent Children (AFDC) with Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF), introducing work requirements, time limits, sanctions, and greater state discretion. While prior research has examined the reform's effects on adults and children's short-run outcomes, less is known about whether early-life exposure shaped the next generation's human capital as they entered young adulthood. This paper studies noncognitive skills (NCS), an overlooked socioemotional dimension of human capital which become more crystalized in that age bandwidth. To address this gap, I link the PSID core survey with the Child Development Supplement and the Transition into Adulthood Supplement, measure exposure to welfare reform from conception through age five, and estimate a triple-difference design that exploits variation across states, birth cohorts, and mothers' likelihood of being affected by the reform.

Greater early-childhood exposure reduced overall NCS among children most likely to be affected. Effects vary across demographic groups, and preliminary mechanism analyses are more consistent with changes in the early caregiving environment than with income or maternal employment alone. To gauge what these skill losses are worth, I use an augmented Mincer decomposition to price the affected traits in the labor market, which confirms they carry economically meaningful returns even as the reduced-form effect on earnings remains null, a pattern pointing to consequences that operate through non-pecuniary dimensions of wellbeing. The paper shows that reforms evaluated largely through adult labor-market outcomes can also shape less visible dimensions of children's human capital many years later, and that credible social-policy evaluation should account for the developmental timing of exposure and for outcomes extending beyond intended recipients.

The dissertation then follows the same exposed cohort deeper into adulthood. In *"From Cradle to Courtroom? Early-Life Exposure to Welfare Reform and Long-Run Criminal Justice Contact,"* I examine arrest, incarceration, and probation, as a consequential and policy relevant marker of disrupted early environments, and as a window on long-run wellbeing. The dissertation's final essay carries the same concern with design and vulnerability to a developing-country setting. In *"Cash Transfers and the Labor Supply of Vulnerable Households and Individuals: Does Household Indebtedness Matter?"*, a joint paper, we examine how pre-existing financial obligations condition responses to Ghana's LEAP 1000 cash transfer. The transfer reduces wage and total work hours on average, consistent with an income effect, yet indebted beneficiaries increase wage work,

nonfarm enterprise activity, and total hours, with responses varying by debt purpose, source, gender, and type of work. Identical transfers can therefore generate sharply different behavioral responses depending on the financial obligations households bring into a program, a lesson about design and heterogeneity that connects the Ghanaian evidence directly to my U.S. work.

Research Foundations and Ongoing Research

Before my dissertation, I built a research program on social protection, household welfare, and institutional engagement in sub-Saharan Africa that continues to anchor my international development agenda. In joint work, I find that broader social-protection coverage is associated with more inclusive growth across the region, that international remittances strengthen multiple dimensions of women's empowerment, and that agricultural extension services improve household assets, food consumption, and dietary diversity in Ghana. A consistent theme is that resources delivered through public programs and private transfers translate into household wellbeing unevenly, in ways that depend on economic and social context, the same heterogeneity that motivates my current work.

A second line examines how citizens understand and engage with policy. In my sole-authored "*Universal Access, Divided Opinions*," published in *Social Policy and Society*, I use latent class analysis to show that Ghana's universal Free Senior High School policy produced distinct configurations of public opinion rather than uniform support. Joint work on corruption reporting examines how education, economic security, civic engagement, and trust shape citizens' willingness to use formal accountability institutions. This work established a conviction that runs through my agenda: policy effectiveness depends not only on benefits and formal rules, but on how citizens interpret those rules, judge their legitimacy, and respond to public institutions.

My current projects naturally extend these questions into new policy settings. One project examines whether Ghana's Free Senior High School reform generated educational spillovers to younger siblings within households, while another studies how administrative burden and political ideology shape public support for SNAP work requirements among college students. Although these projects differ substantively, both continue my broader interest in how policy design, information, and institutions shape individual behavior and long-run opportunity.

Future Directions

My future agenda pursues three complementary directions. In the United States, I will extend my work on welfare reform to other components of the modern safety net, particularly in-kind programs such as SNAP and WIC and tax-based transfers such as the Earned Income Tax Credit and Child Tax Credit. I will examine how differences in policy design, work incentives, and administrative requirements shape household decision-making, financial resilience, labor-market attachment, and children's developmental trajectories, and whether interventions during critical developmental periods generate lasting benefits or unintended consequences.

In sub-Saharan Africa, I will study the long-run consequences of cash transfers beyond their well-documented short-run effects. Much less is known about how these programs shape human capital, labor-market trajectories, and intergenerational mobility years after beneficiaries exit them. I will also develop a complementary agenda on the interaction between public social protection and private safety nets, particularly international remittances, asking when private transfers complement, substitute for, or amplify government programs and how their interaction shapes household investment and long-run mobility.

Finally, I will expand my methodological toolkit by pairing causal inference with microsimulation. Where causal inference identifies the impacts of existing policies, microsimulation can project the long-run consequences of newly enacted reforms before those outcomes are observable, allowing me to inform policy design rather than only evaluate it after the fact. My overarching goal is research that helps policymakers understand for whom policies work, why they work, and how today's choices shape opportunity across generations.